



**Trump card:** Captain Harmanpreet Singh, seen here competing at the Senior National Championship in Chennai, is the most important player for India going into the 2024 Paris Olympics. R. RAGU

Their natural ability, ball skills, and speed are good. The rest of it can be done through practice.

**Young players locked horns with the Indian players after a five-year gap at the Senior Nationals. How important is it for the youngsters?**

Aspiring players should observe how national players conduct themselves and maintain their fitness levels. It's crucial to set a higher standard for domestic players.

Additionally, it's beneficial for young players to have the opportunity to compete against international players so that they can assess their performance and identify areas for improvement.

**What can the Indian team expect from the Paris Olympics?**

We've got a good programme. Eighty per cent of it is complete. We are just not looking at doing anything different. It's what we have been doing well and consistently that will tell.

We have to follow the process properly. How we peak in June and July will be the key.

**What are the areas of concern for the national team?**

It's sometimes how a nation can build expectations that can put unnecessary pressure on a group and expect too much too soon. We have done well. We need to get everyone to get behind us. It is also about the post-Paris Olympics. There needs to be continuous planning. There is the World Cup in 2026. Some players who won't play in Paris will feature in the next cycle. So, there is a continuous treadmill of planning.

**Since the onset of foreign coaches, there has been a change in the fitness levels of players over the years.**

It's just what I said. Doing things consistently is what we have been doing. Our conditioning is massive, and so is the mental side of things. We have a good support staff. It's the basics of how our game is set up. Conditioning is massive. So is the mental side of things. Alan Tan is the strength and conditioning coach. Paddy Upton does mental conditioning. I do that as well. Rhett

Halkett, assistant coach, is heavily involved with tactics. Shiv (Shivendra Singh) is involved with the strikers. They are top-class staff. We rely heavily on them. It is just about the consistency of small improvements over a long period.

**With the Olympics just around the corner, has the pressure cranked up a little?**

I don't think there is more pressure than there was when I took charge in April 2023. I had three competitions for the Indian team to qualify for the Olympics. That is done. There is no real pressure, only expectations of what lies ahead. That is controllable in the way we approach our training and competition.

**What legacy would you like to leave in India?**

Indians are proud of their team across disciplines. It's been a great experience with cricket and how it can inspire the nation. We would like to do that as well.

When we come together, special things happen. We want to do it on a bigger stage. It is not easy. We are pushing to improve on India's performance at the Tokyo Olympics (bronze). We are looking forward to the journey.